

Word family: **earn / earns / earned / earning / earnings / earner**

Base word: earn

Forms: earns, earned, earning

Related forms: earnings, earner

Useful compounds/extensions: hard-earned, wage earner, high earner, earning power, earned income, unearned income

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / related nouns and adjectives (相關名詞及形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “Put simply, tutors **earn private income** while restaurants absorb the hidden overhead.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **earn** means **to receive money in return for work or services provided**.

The tutors receive income from teaching students, while the restaurant bears some of the costs created by those lessons.

繁體中文： **賺取**；因工作、提供服務或勞動而獲得金錢 / 收入

中文翻譯：

> “Tutors **earn private income** ...”

「補習老師從私人補習中**賺取收入**.....」

Here:

earn income = 透過工作或提供服務取得收入

1. **earn = receive money for work or services (工作收入) — 賺取；掙得**

This is the exact meaning in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Tutors **earn** income by teaching students.”

「補習老師透過教學生**賺取收入**。」

Practice 2

> “She **earns** \$20 an hour.”

「她每小時**賺取**二十元。」

Practice 3

> “He **earns** his money by repairing computers.”

「他靠維修電腦**賺錢**。」

earn = 因工作、勞動或提供服務而取得金錢

Common:

- * earn money
- * earn income
- * earn a salary
- * earn wages
- * earn \$50,000 a year

2. **earn a living** = make enough money to support yourself (固定表達) — 謀生；維持生計

Practice 4

> “She **earns a living** as a designer.”

「她靠做設計師**謀生**。」

Practice 5

> “It is difficult to **earn a living** from seasonal work alone.”

「只靠季節性工作很難**維持生計**。」

earn a living = 透過工作取得足以支持日常生活的收入

This belongs to Meaning 1 but is important enough to learn as a fixed expression.

3. **earn** = receive interest, profit, or financial return (投資 / 資產) — 賺取；產生收益

Money or an investment can also **earn** money.

Practice 6

> “The account **earns** interest every month.”

「這個帳戶每月都會**賺取 / 產生利息**。」

Practice 7

> “The investment **earned** a 6% return.”

「這項投資**取得了**百分之六的回報。」

Here, the subject does not necessarily perform labour.

earn = 資金、投資或資產帶來利息、回報或收益

This is a strong financial extension of the money sense.

4. **earn** = gain something through effort, ability, or achievement (努力取得) — 贏得 ; 取得 ; 獲得

Earn is not limited to money.

You can **earn** something because you worked for it or met the required standard.

Practice 8

> “She **earned** a place at the university.”

「她憑自己的表現**取得**大學學位名額。」

Practice 9

> “He **earned** a promotion after years of hard work.”

「他多年努力工作後**獲得**晉升。」

Practice 10

> “Students can **earn** extra credits by completing the project.”

「學生完成這個項目後可以**取得**額外學分。」

earn = 因努力、能力、表現或達到要求而取得某項成果 / 資格 / 機會

Common:

- * earn a degree
- * earn a qualification
- * earn a promotion
- * earn a place
- * earn points
- * earn credits
- * earn a medal

5. **earn a degree / qualification = complete the requirements successfully (學業) — 取得學位 / 資格**

Practice 11

> “She **earned** a degree in engineering.”

「她**取得了**工程學學位。」

This usually means she successfully completed the required study and assessment.

Compare:

> **get a degree**

neutral

versus:

> **earn a degree**

emphasizes satisfying the requirements through effort/achievement.

For core counting, this belongs to Meaning 4.

6. **earn = gain respect, trust, admiration, reputation, etc. through behaviour (抽象結果) — 贏得 ; 博得**

Practice 12

> “She quickly **earned** the respect of her colleagues.”

「她很快便**贏得**同事的尊重。」

Practice 13

> “It takes time to **earn** people’s trust.”

「**贏得**別人的信任需要時間。」

Practice 14

> “His work **earned** him international recognition.”

「他的工作為他**贏得了**國際認可。」

****earn = 因自己的行為、能力或表現而逐漸得到別人的尊重、信任、認可等****

This is one of the most important figurative senses.

7. ****earn = acquire a reputation or label because of what you do (名聲) — 博得；落得；得到****

Importantly, what you ****earn**** does not have to be positive.

Practice 15

> “The company ****earned**** a reputation for reliability.”

「這家公司****建立 / 贏得了****可靠的聲譽。」

Practice 16

> “His behaviour ****earned**** him a bad reputation.”

「他的行為令他****落得****壞名聲。」

So:

****earn ≠ always receive something desirable****

The idea is:

> your actions cause that result to become associated with you.

For strict counting, this belongs with Meaning 6.

8. **earn = deserve something because of your actions (應得) — 應得；值得獲得**

Sometimes **earn** emphasizes that the result is justified by what someone has done.

Practice 17

> “You’ve **earned** a rest.”

「你已經很努力，**應該好好休息 / 這個休息是你應得的**。」

Practice 18

> “Her performance **earned** her the award.”

「她的表現令她**實至名歸地獲得**這個獎項。」

Here the underlying idea is:

> **what you did makes the reward/result deserved**

This overlaps with Meaning 4/6 but is a very important semantic nuance.

9. **earn someone something = cause someone to receive a result (雙賓語結構) — 為某人贏得 / 招致**

A very productive structure is:

> **something earns someone something**

Practice 19

> “The goal **earned** the team three points.”

「這個入球為球隊**贏得**三分。」

Practice 20

> “The mistake **earned** him a warning.”

「這個錯誤令他**招致**一次警告。」

Practice 21

> “Her honesty ****earned**** her their trust.”

「她的誠實為她****贏得了****他們的信任。」

Notice that the result can be:

* positive: respect, award, points

* negative: warning, criticism, punishment

So ****earn**** here means:

****某個行為 / 表現造成某人取得或招致某個結果****

10. ****earn points / miles / rewards (獎勵制度) — 賺取 / 累積積分、里數、獎賞****

A common modern commercial use:

Practice 22

> “Customers ****earn**** points on every purchase.”

「顧客每次消費都可以****賺取 / 累積積分****。」

Practice 23

> “You can ****earn**** airline miles by using the card.”

「使用這張卡可以****累積航空里數****。」

This belongs to Meaning 4: obtain something by satisfying a condition or performing an activity.

11. ****earn one's keep = work enough to justify one's food/support (固定表達) — 做工抵償生活費；證明自己值得被供養****

Traditionally:

> ****earn your keep****

means work enough to compensate for the cost of supporting you.

Practice 24

> “Everyone on the farm was expected to **earn their keep**.”

「農場上的每個人都要工作，以**換取自己的食宿 / 維持自己的生活所需**。」

It can also be used figuratively for objects:

> “The old machine still earns its keep.”

= 那部舊機器仍然**有足夠用途，值得留下使用**。

This is a useful idiom.

12. **earn one's stripes** = prove one's ability or experience (固定表達) — 證明實力；靠經驗取得認可

Practice 25

> “She **earned her stripes** by handling several difficult projects.”

「她透過處理幾個困難項目**證明了自己的實力**。」

earn your stripes = 經過實際努力 / 經驗後取得資格、地位或別人認可

This is figurative and informal.

Related form: **earnings**

Earnings is very important and has two main uses.

earnings = money a person earns from work (收入) — 收入；薪酬所得

Practice 26

> “Her monthly **earnings** increased.”

「她每月的**收入**增加了。」

earnings = 因工作而取得的收入

earnings = company profit/income in financial reporting (企業財務) — 盈利 ; 收益

In business and investing, **earnings** commonly refers to a company's profit, especially net income.

Practice 27

> “The company reported higher quarterly **earnings**.”

「公司公布季度**盈利**上升。」

Common:

* quarterly earnings

* earnings report

* earnings per share (EPS)

This financial use is important because:

> personal earnings = 個人收入

but:

> corporate earnings = 公司盈利

The Chinese translation changes with context.

Related form: **earning**

As a gerund:

> “Earning money takes time.”

「**賺錢**需要時間。」

As a modifier:

> earning capacity

> earning potential

means:

> ability/potential to generate income.

Related form: **earner**

An **earner** is a person or thing that earns money.

Practice 28

> “She is the main **earner** in the family.”

「她是家庭主要的**收入來源者 / 主要賺錢的人**。」

Common:

- * high earner
- * low earner
- * wage earner
- * top earner
- * income earner

It can also describe a product:

> “The product is a strong earner.”

= 這件產品是很能**賺錢的產品 / 主要收入來源**。

Related form: **hard-earned**

Hard-earned means gained only through considerable effort.

Practice 29

> “People do not want to waste their **hard-earned** money.”

「人們不想浪費自己**辛苦賺來的**錢。」

Practice 30

> “She took a **hard-earned** break.”

「她終於得到一段**辛苦爭取回來 / 應得的**休息時間。」

This can modify:

- * money
- * success
- * reputation
- * victory
- * rest

Related term: **earned income**

In tax/accounting language, **earned income** generally means income obtained through work or active services, such as wages or self-employment income.

繁體中文： **勞動所得 / 工作收入**

The exact legal/tax definition depends on jurisdiction.

Related term: **unearned income**

Unearned income commonly refers to income not obtained directly through performing work, such as certain investment or passive income.

繁體中文： **非勞動所得**

Again, exact tax definitions depend on jurisdiction.

Important distinction: **earn vs make**

For money:

earn money

emphasizes obtaining money through:

- * work
- * service
- * effort
- * investment return

make money

is broader:

- > make money from a business
- > make money selling products

Both are natural, but **earn** more clearly suggests income received in return for something.

Important distinction: **earn** vs **get**

get

is neutral:

- > get a promotion

earn

emphasizes that the outcome resulted from effort, ability, behaviour, or meeting requirements:

- > earn a promotion

So **earn** carries more of the idea:

- > **you did something to merit/produce the result**

Important distinction: **earn** vs **win**

win

often involves:

- * competition
- * contest
- * chance

earn

emphasizes:

- * effort
- * merit
- * performance

Compare:

- > win a prize in a lottery
- > earn an award through years of work

There is overlap with sporting awards.

Important distinction: ****earn vs deserve****

****deserve****

means:

- > be worthy of receiving something.

It does not necessarily mean you actually received it.

- > “She deserves an award.”

= 她值得得獎，但未必已經得獎。

****earn****

often suggests your actions have produced or justified the outcome:

- > “She earned an award.”

= 她憑表現取得了獎項。

So:

****deserve = 值得****

****earn = 憑努力 / 表現取得****

Important distinction: ****earn vs gain****

****gain****

is broad and means obtain/increase.

****earn****

specifically suggests the result comes from effort, activity, achievement, or merit.

- > gain experience

- > earn respect

You can ****gain**** respect accidentally over time; ****earn**** strongly emphasizes that your conduct caused people to respect you.

Important distinction: ****earn vs receive****

****receive****

simply means something is given to you.

****earn****

explains ****why**** you received it:

- > because of work, performance, behaviour, or qualification.

- > receive a salary

- > earn a salary

Both are possible, but the perspective differs.

Important distinction: ****earnings vs income****

****income****

is the broad term for money received from various sources.

****earnings****

often means:

- * money generated through work; or

- * company profit.

So someone may have income from investments that is not employment ****earnings****.

Important distinction: ****earnings vs revenue — company context****

For a company:

****revenue****

= money brought in from sales/business activities before relevant expenses are deducted.

****earnings****

usually = profit/net income after expenses.

So:

> revenue ≠ earnings

This is especially important in financial news.

Grammar note: ****earn + amount****

> earn \$500 a week

> earn £40,000 a year

No preposition is needed.

Grammar note: ****earn + thing/result****

> earn respect

> earn trust

> earn a degree

> earn points

> earn a promotion

Grammar note: ****earn someone something****

> “The result earned her a place in the final.”

Structure:

****subject + earn + person + result****

= 某件事為某人帶來 / 贏得某結果

Grammar note: ****earn money from/by****

****earn money from + source****

> “She earns money from tutoring.”

****earn money by + activity****

> “She earns money by teaching online.”

Both are useful.

Countability note

****Earn**** is a verb.

****earnings****

normally plural in form:

> annual earnings

> total earnings

We do not ordinarily say:

> an earning 

when referring to salary/income.

****earner****

is countable:

> an earner

> high earners

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **earn**
* **earns**
* **earned**
* **earning**
* **earnings**
* **earner**
* **hard-earned**

Useful compounds/constructions:

* earn money
* earn income
* earn a living
* earn interest
* earn a return
* earn respect
* earn trust
* earn a degree
* earn points
* earn one's keep
* earn one's stripes
* earning power
* earning potential
* earned income

A broad audit shows that most uses organize around one powerful concept:

> **something is obtained as the result of work, effort, performance, behaviour, or productive value**

But the **financial-yield** branch deserves explicit treatment because the subject can be an account or investment rather than a person doing work.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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earn — work/income	因工作、勞動或提供服務而取得金錢 / 收入
earn a living	透過工作取得足以維持生活的收入；謀生
earn — investment	資金 / 投資產生利息、收益或回報
earn — achievement	因努力、能力或達到要求而取得資格、機會、分數、學位等
earn — respect/trust	因行為或表現而逐漸贏得尊重、信任、認可或名聲

earn — deserve/result	因自己的行為而應得 / 招致某種結果	
earn someone something	某項行為、表現或事件為某人帶來某種結果	
earn one's keep	工作以抵償自己的食宿 / 證明自己值得被供養	
earn one's stripes	透過經驗及努力證明能力並取得認可	
earnings — individual	個人因工作取得的收入	
earnings — company	公司盈利 / 收益，常指利潤	
earner	賺取收入的人或能產生收入的事物	
hard-earned	經過大量努力才取得的；辛苦賺來的	

For your original sentence

> “Tutors ****earn private income**** while restaurants absorb the hidden overhead.”

The exact meaning is:

****earn = 補習老師透過向學生提供私人補習服務而取得金錢收入****

So:

> ****earn private income****

= ****透過私人服務賺取收入****

The sentence creates a contrast:

> tutors ****receive financial benefit****

> while restaurants ****bear part of the cost****

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****earn****:

1. ****receive money in return for work or services****
2. ****produce financial return or interest — an investment/account earns****
3. ****gain/deserve something through effort, achievement, behaviour, or merit****

I would merge ****earn a degree, earn points, earn respect, earn trust, earn a reputation, earn a promotion**** into #3, while keeping the very productive ****earn someone something**** construction explicit. ****Earnings****, ****earner****, and ****hard-earned**** deserve family coverage because each is common and semantically useful.